

VOLUME I

Mūlapaṇṇāsa Pāli

The Root Fifty Discourses

MN 1 - 50

Mūlapariyāya Vagga

The Division of the Discourse on the Root

MN 1 - 10

1 - Mūlapariyāya Sutta

The Root of All Things

This is one of the most philosophically demanding suttas in the entire collection. The Buddha explains how the untrained mind automatically turns every experience into a platform for ego and identity — and how the awakened mind perceives the same experiences without that distortion. Do not be discouraged if it feels difficult; it rewards patient, repeated reading.

The Root of All Things:

How the Mind Claims Reality

Step 1: Accurate Perception

Perceives earth as earth,
acknowledging the physical
property through the senses.

Step 2: Mental Conceiving

The mind begins to "imagine" or construe
the experience as a self-related entity.

Conceiving oneself
as "in earth".

Conceiving oneself as
"earth as mine".

Conceiving oneself as
"apart from earth".

Conceiving oneself as
"to be earth".

The Root of Suffering

The Trap of "Approval"

By delighting in these mental
constructs, one becomes
tethered to craving.

The Lack of Complete Understanding

This process occurs because the
individual has not yet fully realized
the conditioned nature of all things.

The Root is Craving

Taking pleasure in identification is
the fundamental root from which
all suffering and rebirth grow.

He perceives
earth as earth.

He conceives
earth.

...conceives
in earth.

...conceives
apart from earth.

...conceives
"earth is mine."

...delights
in earth.

Conceiving
(Maññanā)

↓
Ignorance
(Avijjā)

↓
I-

↓
Mine

↓
Delight

↓
Bondage

Why is that? Because he has not fully understood it, I say.

THE ROOT OF ALL THINGS: THE TRAP OF CONCEIVING

THE ORDINARY PERSON'S TRAP: THE "EARTH" EXAMPLE

From Perception to Ownership

The ordinary person perceives earth, then conceives themselves "in" or "as" earth, claiming it as "mine".

The Delusion of Delight

Because they do not fully understand the nature of reality, they take delight in earth.

Conceiving the Self

Creating a false identity by seeing the self as either the same as, within, or separate from the world.

A comparison of how the mind creates a self through perception, leading to suffering, based on the Mūlapariyāya Sutta (MN 1).

THE ENLIGHTENED VIEW AND THE UNEXPECTED ENDING

Direct Knowledge vs. Conceiving

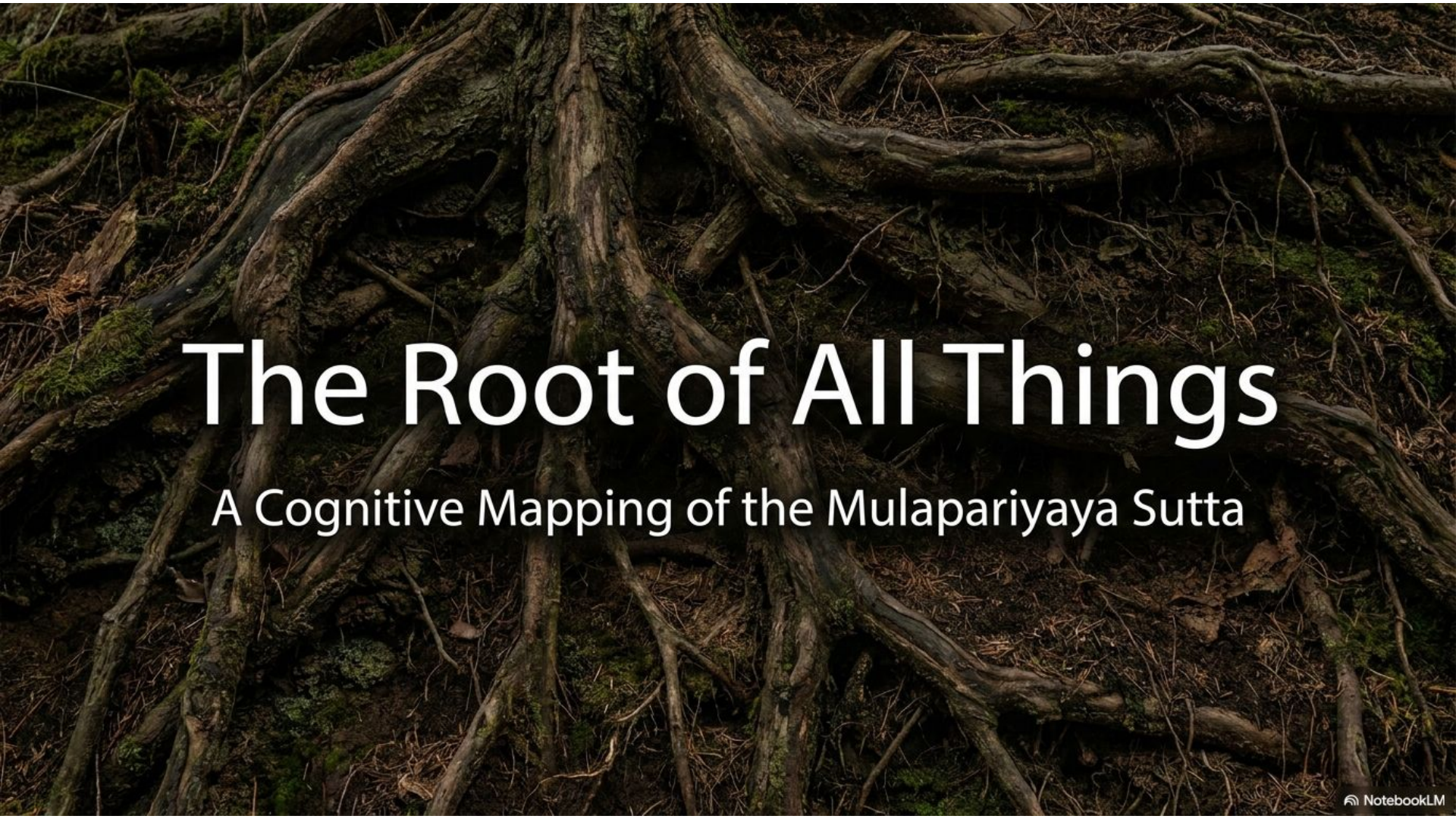
Unlike the ordinary person, the Arahant "directly knows" reality but does not conceive a self within it.

Delight as the Root of Suffering

The Buddha teaches that delight leads to birth, aging, and death, requiring the relinquishing of all cravings.

A RARE REACTION OF DISCOMFORT

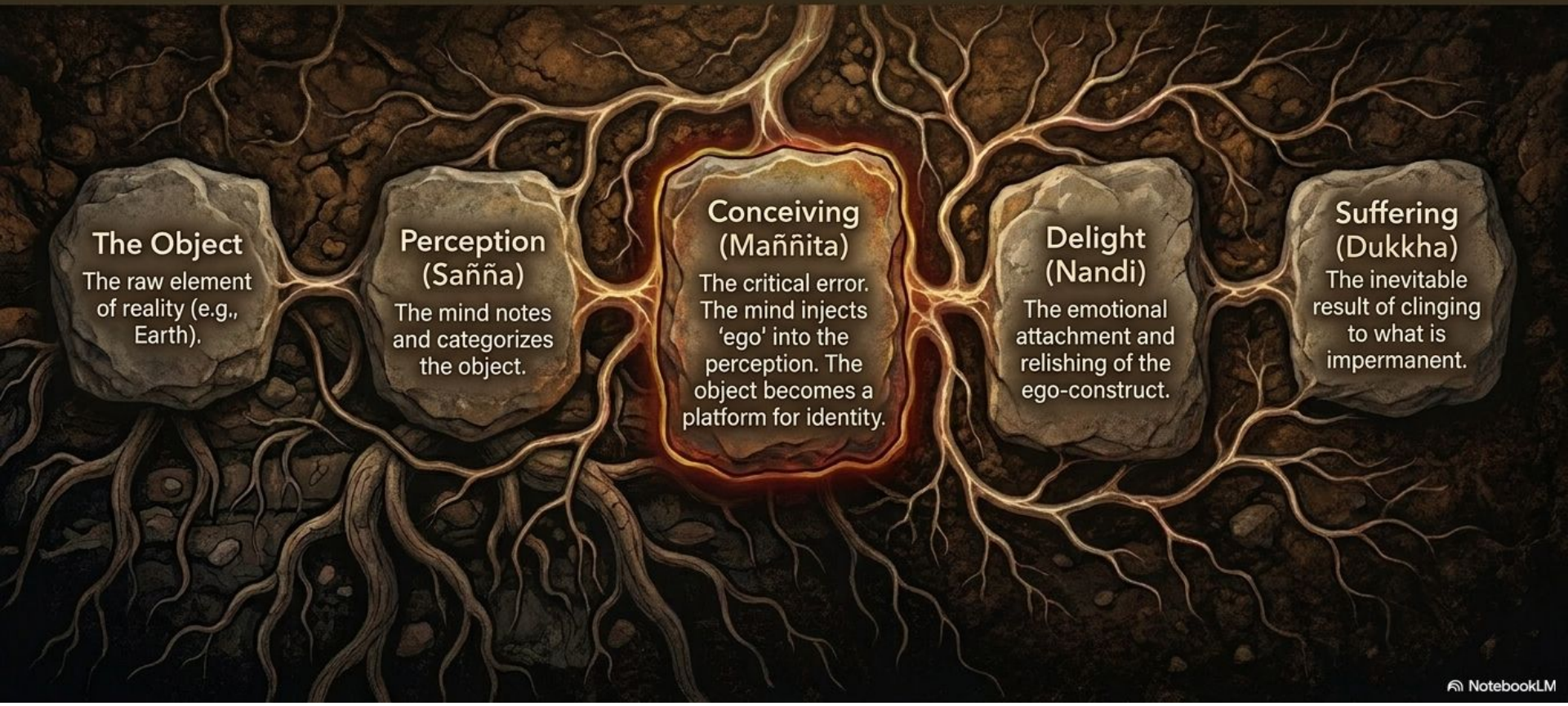
"Those bhikkhus did not delight in the Blessed One's words."



The Root of All Things

A Cognitive Mapping of the Mulapariyaya Sutta

The Cognitive Chain Reaction

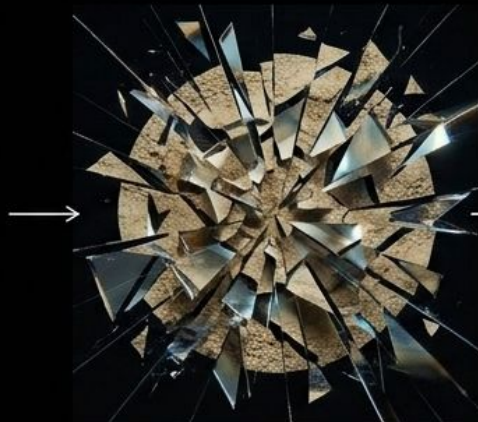


The Ontological Trap: The Mechanics of Delusion



Step 1: Contact / Perceiving

Bare Perception (e.g., "Earth as Earth"). The object is simply registered.



Step 2: The Egoic Pivot

Conceiving (Maññāti). The mind injects the illusion of an observer into the observation. Bare data is conceptualized into a relationship with "I".



Step 3: Delight

Attachment. The ego claims ownership or affinity, creating "delight."



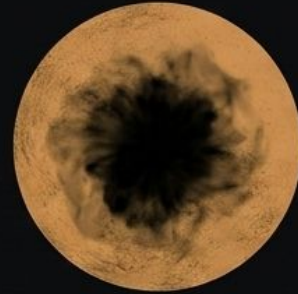
Step 4: Suffering

The Inevitable Result. Delight becomes the root of suffering.

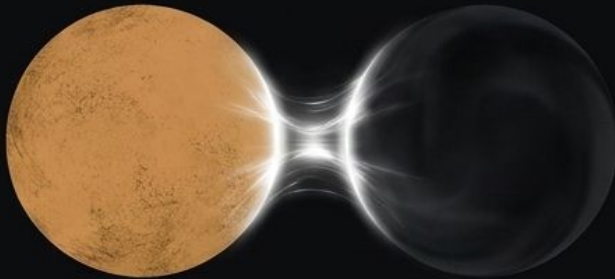
The Fourfold Architecture of 'I-Making'



Quadrant 1: Conceives himself AS earth. (Identity)



Quadrant 2: Conceives himself IN earth. (Immanence)



Quadrant 3: Conceives himself APART FROM earth. (Duality / Separation)



Quadrant 4: Conceives earth to be 'MINE'. (Possession)



The Fatal Consequence: Delight

*...he delights in earth.
Why is that? Because he
has not fully understood
it, I say.*

The egoic construction inevitably breeds delight/attachment. Because the fundamental nature of the object (impermanent, not-self) is entirely obscured by the conceptual overlay, the mind eagerly grasps at it.

Scaling the Cosmos: The 24 Bases of Reality

The untaught mind applies the exact same fourfold egoic trap to dirt as it does to the highest meditative states.
No realm is safe from conception.

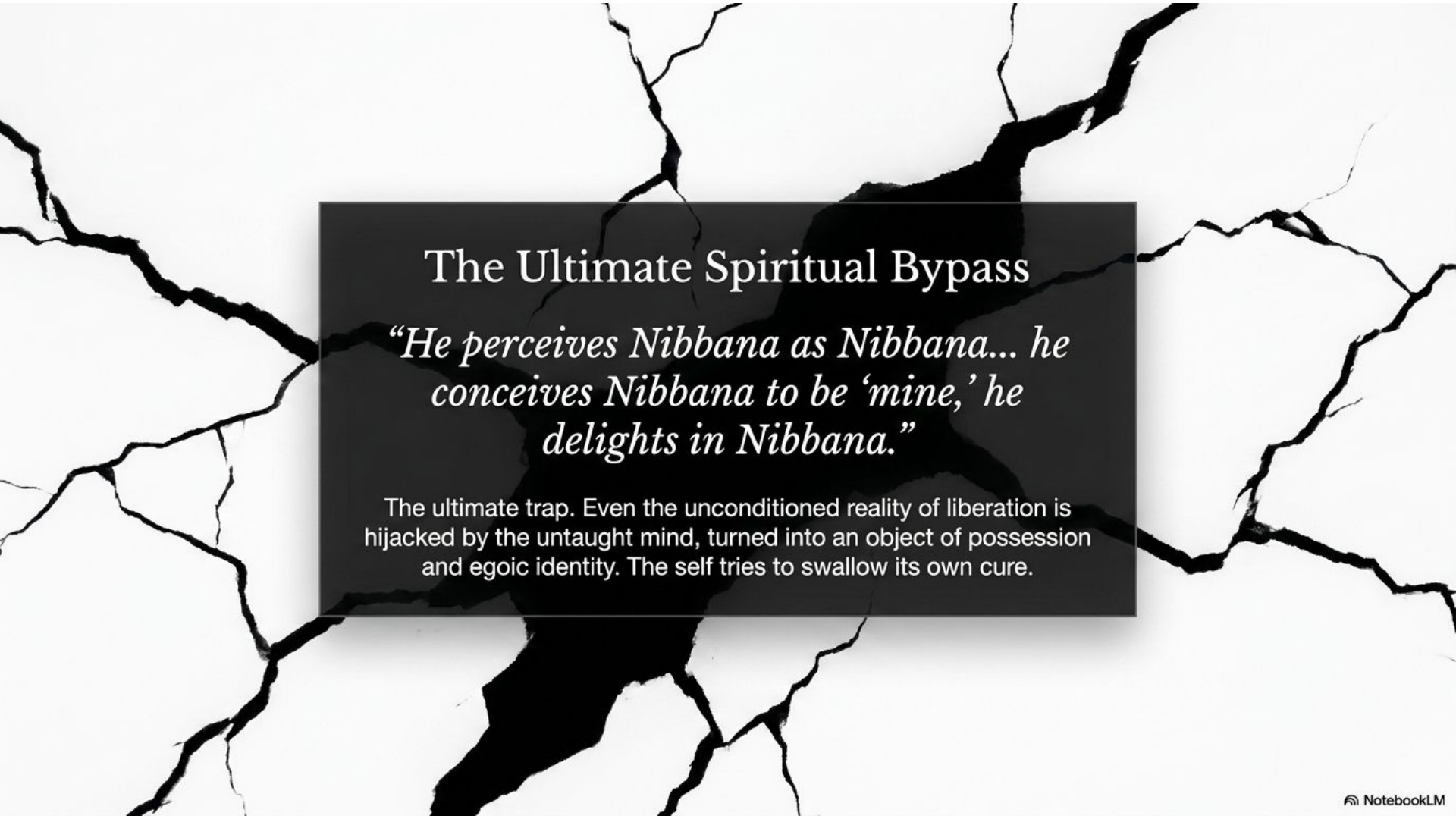


Rung 4 (The Cognitive Spheres):
The Seen, Heard, Sensed, Cognized.

Rung 3 (The Formless Realms):
Infinite Space, Infinite
Consciousness, Nothingness,
Neither-Perception-Nor-Non-Perception.

Rung 2 (The Beings & Gods):
Beings, Gods, Pajapati, Brahma.

Rung 1 (The Gross Elements):
Earth, Water, Fire, Air.



The Ultimate Spiritual Bypass

*“He perceives Nibbana as Nibbana... he
conceives Nibbana to be ‘mine,’ he
delights in Nibbana.”*

The ultimate trap. Even the unconditioned reality of liberation is hijacked by the untaught mind, turned into an object of possession and egoic identity. The self tries to swallow its own cure.

The Architecture of Delusion

The Buddha identifies four subtle modes in which the mind constructs an identity around an object.



As the Object

The ego fully identifies with the phenomenon.

'He conceives himself as earth.'



In the Object

The ego feels contained within the phenomenon.

'He conceives himself in earth.'



Apart from the Object

The ego defines itself relationally against the phenomenon.

'He conceives himself apart from earth.'

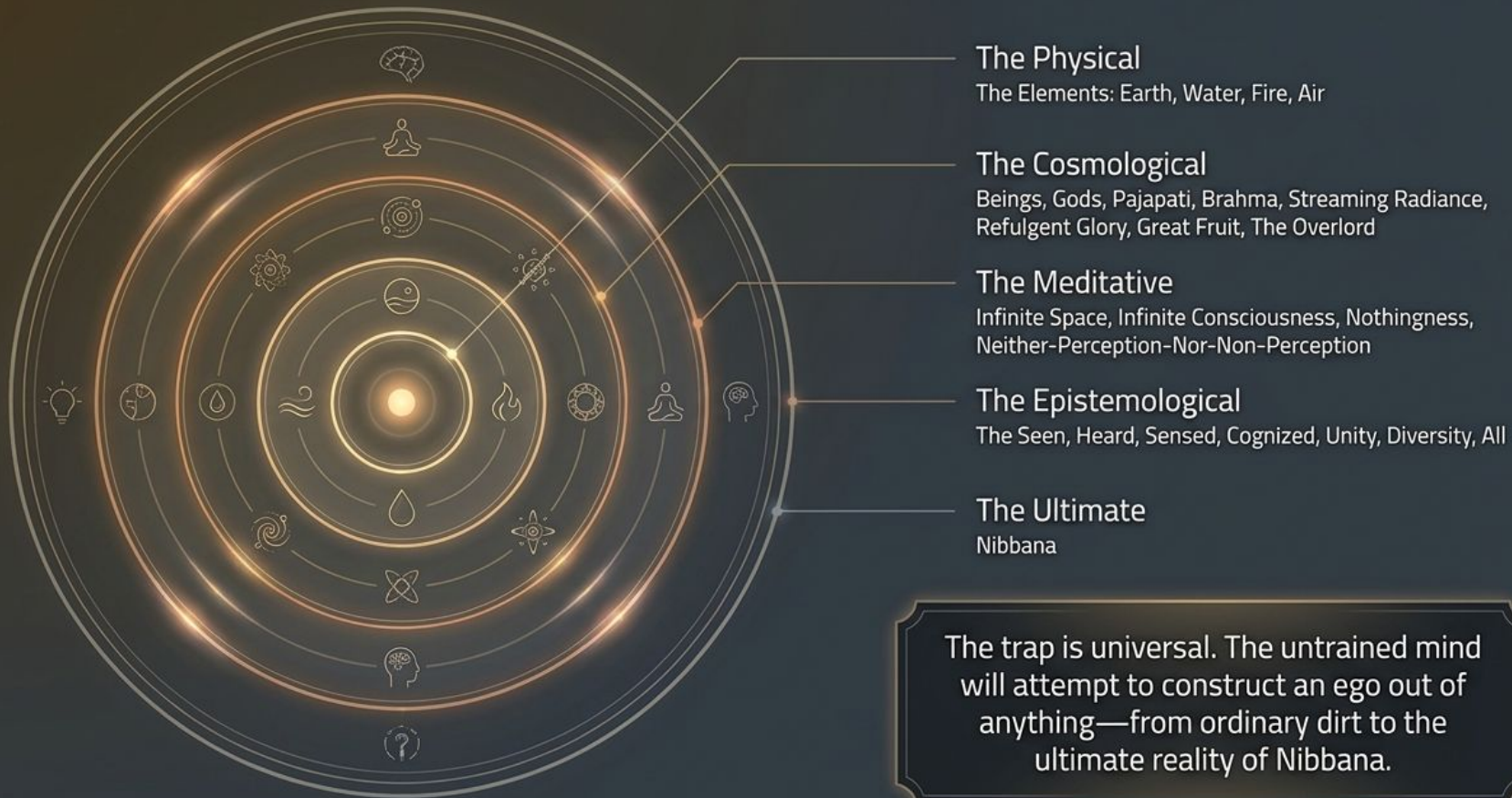


As "Mine"

The ego claims ownership and possession.

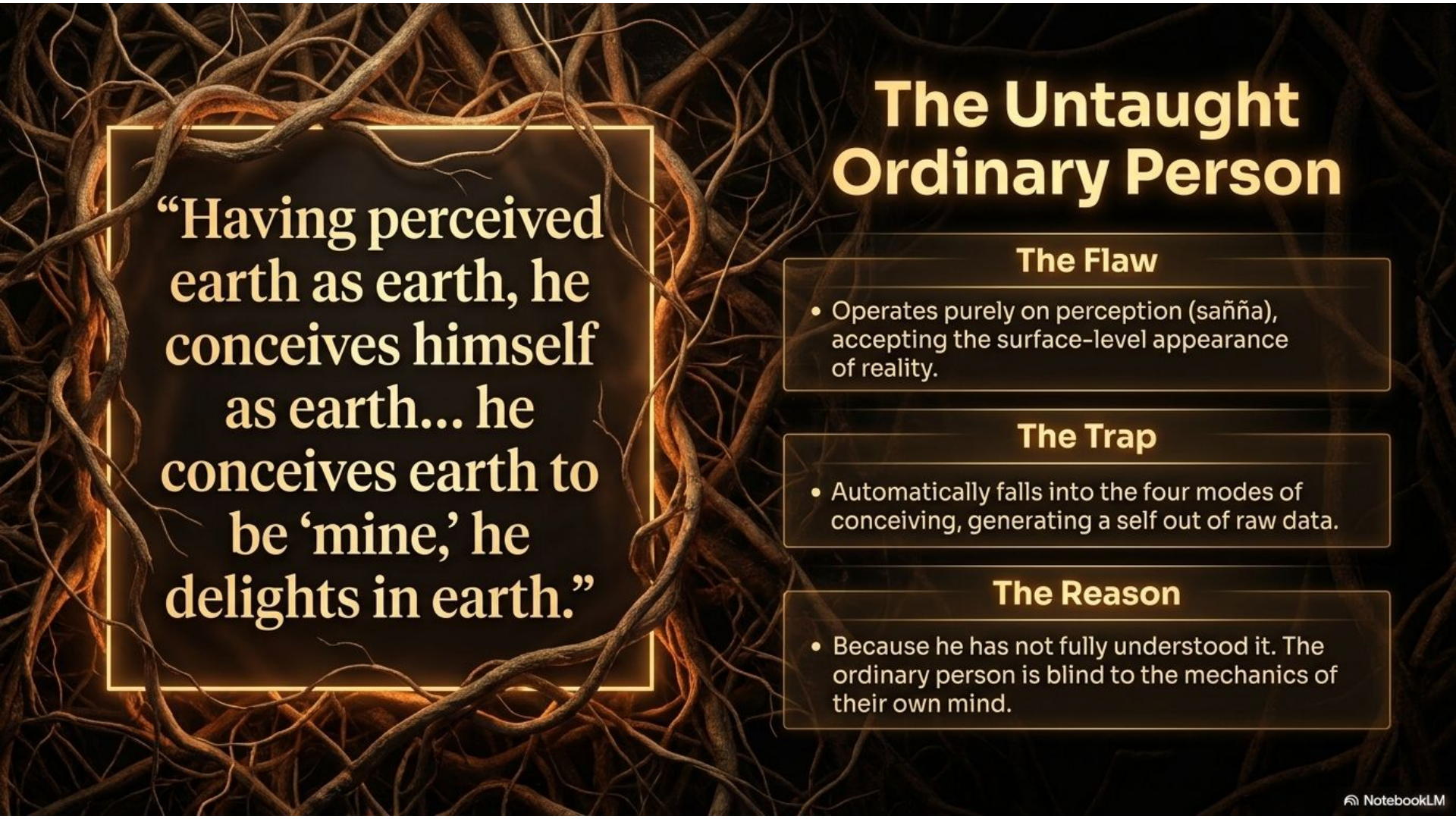
'He conceives earth to be mine.'

The Territory of Clinging



The Epistemological Matrix

	The Ordinary Person	The Disciple (Sekha)	The Arahant	The Tathagata
Cognitive Action	Perceives	Directly Knows	Directly Knows	Directly Knows
Ego Action	Conceives	Should not conceive	Does not conceive	Does not conceive
Emotional Action	Delights	Should not delight	Does not delight	Does not delight
Reasoning	Has not understood it	Must fully understand it	Has fully understood it	Has fully understood it to the end



“Having perceived earth as earth, he conceives himself as earth... he conceives earth to be ‘mine,’ he delights in earth.”

The Untaught Ordinary Person

The Flaw

- Operates purely on perception (sañña), accepting the surface-level appearance of reality.

The Trap

- Automatically falls into the four modes of conceiving, generating a self out of raw data.

The Reason

- Because he has not fully understood it. The ordinary person is blind to the mechanics of their own mind.

The Disciple in Higher Training (Sekha)

The mind is shifting toward liberation, but the work is incomplete. The Disciple experiences a fundamental upgrade in cognition—moving from surface perception to direct knowledge—but must actively defend against the habit of ego-formation.

1. He directly knows earth as earth.



2. He should not conceive himself as earth.



3. He should not delight in earth.



The Reason

"So that he may fully understand it."
Liberation at this stage requires
conscious restraint and effort.

The Arahant

The active restraint of the Disciple becomes the effortless reality of the Arahant. The root has been completely severed.



He directly knows earth as earth.



He does not conceive himself as earth.



He does not delight in earth.

The Reason

“Because he has fully understood it.”

The Arahant no longer generates an ego because the fuel is gone. They are entirely free from lust, free from hate, and free from delusion through their absolute destruction.

The Tathagata

The Accomplished and Fully Enlightened One. The Tathagata shares the exact same operational reality as the Arahant—he directly knows, does not conceive, and does not delight.

The Distinction

While the Arahant has fully understood reality, the Tathagata has “fully understood it to the end.”

The Buddha possesses the supreme, unshakeable mastery of the system he himself discovered and articulated.

The Philosophical Root

He has understood
that delight is the
root of suffering.

The ultimate realization. The Tathagata sees that with being as a condition, there is birth, and whatever comes to be is subject to aging and death. Through the complete destruction, fading away, cessation, giving up, and relinquishing of all cravings, the Tathagata awakens to supreme full enlightenment. The trap is permanently dismantled.

The Paradoxical Close

That is what the Blessed One said.
But those bhikus did not delight in the
Blessed One's words.

This is not a failure of the teaching, but its ultimate triumph. To 'delight' in the Buddha's words would be to immediately rebuild the trap—to conceive the teaching as 'mine', to inject ego into the Dhamma, and to plant a new root of suffering.

The monks received the ultimate teaching on non-attachment, and they proved they understood it by refusing to attach even to the discourse itself.